FREE CHEAT SHEET

How to prompt ChatGPT vs Claude vs Codex

The same task, written three ways. All three understand plain English, so there is no magic syntax. What changes is what each one's official guide asks you to put first. This sheet sums up those guides on four pages.

	ChatGPT	Claude	Codex
SHAPE	Goal, context, output, boundaries. Use only the parts that help.	A clear, direct brief. Put your material and your instructions in separate XML tags.	The behaviour you want, where it lives in the code, the constraints, and how to check it.
BEST MOVE	Say how you will use the result, then improve it with follow-up messages.	Explain why a rule matters. Give 3 to 5 examples in <example> tags.	Give reproduction steps and ask it to run the tests. Put standing rules in AGENTS.md.
WATCH FOR	Long, heavily formatted answers. Name the format and length you want.	"Suggest changes" gets you suggestions. Say "change this" when you want it done.	Vague goals with no way to verify them. Always say how to check the work.
STANDING RULES	Settings, then Personalization (custom instructions)	A one-line role at the top of the prompt, or in the system prompt	An AGENTS.md file, which Codex reads before it starts work

True for all three

- **Context beats clever wording.** Say who it is for, where it will be used and what it must not change.
- **Examples steer tone and format** better than adjectives do.
- **Ask for a final check** against your own criteria, then review the result yourself before you use it.

> Model names and features change often. The tips here follow the official guides from OpenAI and Anthropic as of October 2026. The sources are listed on page 4.

CHATGPT

Start with the result, in plain words

OpenAI's prompting guide says you don't need "technical syntax or a rigid formula". For bigger tasks, it suggests including the parts that matter: **Goal**, **Context**, **Output** and **Boundaries**. Describe the result rather than a list of steps.

TEMPLATE · COPY & PASTE

[Goal] Turn ___ into ___ for ___.
[Context] Here is what you need to know: ___ (attach the file or paste it).
[Output] Make it a ___ (email / table / one-page summary), about ___ words.
[Boundaries] Keep ___ unchanged. Flag missing information instead of guessing.

EXAMPLE

Turn these meeting notes into a short update for my two part-time staff. Put the decisions and next steps first, as a bulleted list of no more than 8 lines. Keep the dates exactly as written, and flag anything that has no owner. [paste notes]

- Say how you will use the result. It helps ChatGPT choose the right length and layout.
- The first prompt doesn't have to be perfect. Follow up with one specific change: "Make the opening more direct."
- Put preferences you want in every chat in your custom instructions, and keep one-off details in the prompt.

CLAUDE

A clear brief, with labelled parts

Anthropic's guide says to think of Claude as "a brilliant but new employee who lacks context on your norms and workflows". Be specific, explain why, and use XML tags to keep your material apart from your instructions.

TEMPLATE · COPY & PASTE

You are ___ (one-line role).
<context>___ (who it's for, and why it matters)</context>
<material>___ (paste the document, data or notes)</material>
<examples><example>___</example></examples>
<task>Do ___. Format: ___. Before you finish, check it against ___.</task>

- With long documents, put the material first and your question last.
- Say what to do rather than what not to do: "Write in flowing paragraphs" works better than "no bullet points".

CODEX

Behaviour, place, constraints, check

Codex is OpenAI's coding agent. It works in your code: it reads files, runs commands in a sandbox and edits code. OpenAI's guide says a useful Codex prompt "names the behavior you want, points to the relevant code or reproduction steps, preserves important constraints, and says how to verify the change."

TEMPLATE · COPY & PASTE

Goal: ___ (the behaviour you want, or the bug you see).
Where: ___ (files or folders, e.g. @src/cart.js).
Repro: 1) ___ 2) ___ 3) ___ (for bugs).
Constraints: don't change ___. Keep the fix small.
Verify: reproduce it first, then fix it, run ___ (tests or lint) and report the commands and results.

- For bigger jobs, type `/plan` first. Codex looks around and proposes an approach before it edits anything.
- In the CLI, mention files with `@`. The IDE extension already sees the files you have open.
- Run `/review` before you commit, to get a second look.

AGENTS.md: rules Codex reads every time

Codex reads `AGENTS.md` files before it does any work. There is a global one in `~/.codex/` and one per project. Files nearer to the folder you work in override the ones above them.

EXAMPLE AGENTS.md

```
# AGENTS.md
## Working agreements
- Run npm test after changing JavaScript files.
- Ask before adding new production dependencies.
- Keep all customer-facing text in British English.
```

SAME TASK, THREE WAYS

CHATGPT	"In Google Sheets, column A has order dates and column C has amounts. Write a formula for monthly totals on a new tab, and explain it in one line. Don't change my columns."
CLAUDE	"<sheet>Date | Customer | Amount, plus 3 sample rows</sheet> <task>One formula for monthly totals. My accountant reads this tab, so keep it simple.</task>"
CODEX	"Add monthly_totals() to reports/sales.py that reads data/orders.csv. Keep the CSV format. Add a test with 3 rows, run pytest and report the result."

BEFORE YOU PRESS SEND

A 30-second check

- Could a new colleague follow this prompt without asking you anything? If not, add the missing context.
- Did you say what the result is for and who will read it?
- Did you name the format and length?
- Is there one boundary that prevents a real problem, such as "keep the prices unchanged" or "draft only, don't send"?
- For Codex, did you say how to verify the change?

Learn more, free

Our Claude guide has a structure template and ready examples at **carlssonandcolibrary.se/learn/claude/**. You'll find more free prompts at **carlssonandcolibrary.se/free/**.

Sources

These are the official guides this cheat sheet sums up, read in October 2026. Quotes are short and come from these pages. Check them for the latest details, because models and features change.

- OpenAI, "Prompting: write useful prompts for Chat, ChatGPT Work, and Codex": developers.openai.com/codex/prompting
- OpenAI, "Prompt engineering": platform.openai.com/docs/guides/prompt-engineering
- OpenAI, latest-model prompting best practices: developers.openai.com/api/docs/guides/latest-model
- OpenAI, "Custom instructions with AGENTS.md": developers.openai.com/codex/guides/agents-md
- Anthropic, "Prompting best practices": docs.anthropic.com/en/docs/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/claude-4-best-practices
- Anthropic, "Prompt engineering overview": docs.anthropic.com/en/docs/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/overview

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